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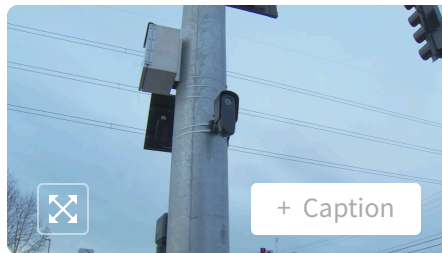
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LOCAL

Everett flips Flock cameras back on under new state law



By [Julia Dallas,](#)
[MyNorthwest.com](#)

April 23, 2026 at 1:45 pm PDT



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EVERETT, Wash. — The City of Everett has turned its Flock cameras, a popular type of automated license plate reader (ALPR), back on after a new state law took effect, exempting ALPR footage from the Public Records Act.

A city spokesperson confirmed with [***The Everett Herald***](#) that the camera network was restarted in early April following the signing of [**Senate Bill 6002**](#) (SB 6002). Under the new law, police can use ALPR data when investigating felonies or gross misdemeanors, stolen vehicles, or missing persons, according to [**Flock Safety**](#). However, data collected by the cameras can only be retained for 21 days, and the cameras cannot be used near protected places such as schools, places of worship, healthcare facilities, immigration facilities, and food banks.

Everett city leaders turned off the cameras in February after a judge ruled the footage was public record, according to [***The Everett Herald***](#). City officials argued the footage shouldn't be available for public use to protect crime victims and victims of domestic violence and stalking.

The recent legislation bars ALPR footage from the Public Records Act, making city leaders more comfortable with leaving the cameras on.

"This new state law ensures that we can protect the privacy of residents – including victims of domestic violence, harassment, and stalking – from anyone who may have had the intention of misusing this information," city spokesperson Simone Tarver told *The Everett Herald* in a statement.

A patchwork response to Flock cameras statewide

Renton paused its ALPR cameras as well, not over public records concerns, but to verify that the network complies with the new state law. The City of Renton [**announced Wednesday**](#) that it turned the system back on.

"We thoroughly evaluated the new law, updated our policies, strengthened data governance and retention protocols, and reinforced accountability measures to align with current legal and community expectations," the department stated.

Meanwhile, [**Pierce County Sheriff Keith Swank**](#), who has been vocal about his disdain for SB 6002, decided to indefinitely deactivate Pierce County's Flock camera system, claiming it's now useless.

Swank argued the ban on Flock cameras near protected places like schools is impossible to comply with because the cameras can't be turned off manually.

“It’s not possible to do it manually,” he told KIRO Newsradio. “Can you imagine this? You’re running code, lights, and a siren to a shooting, and then you go, ‘Oh my gosh, I gotta remember to turn off the camera here, because I’m going to get close to within 500 feet of a school on my way to the school shooting or whatever,’ right? I mean, no, it’s, it’s ridiculous.”

The Spokane County Sheriff’s Office (SCSO) announced earlier this month [via Facebook](#) that it was deactivating its ALPR technology and associated systems.

“This new state law imposes significant restrictions on ALPR systems, some of which were ill-considered, leading us to make this difficult decision,” SCSO stated in its post. “We are assessing how we continue using this crucial law enforcement tool inside the boundaries set by this new law. We did not make this choice lightly, and we believe the legislation as passed is making our community less safe.”

Washington Governor Bob Ferguson said the reset is necessary to protect community privacy.

“This is also about Washington’s constitution and the fact that we need to respect the privacy of all individuals anytime we take on technology, particularly surveillance technology,” Ferguson said.

In mid-March, Seattle Mayor Katie Wilson ordered an audit of the city’s surveillance camera pilot program and [halted its expansion](#), though existing cameras stayed active. Weeks earlier, Lynnwood had gone further, with its city council voting unanimously in February [to cancel](#) the Flock Safety contract altogether, making it the first city in Washington to do so over privacy concerns.

Contributing: Jillian Raftery, KIRO Newsradio

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